

THE SYNDICATE MARKET

A Game of Influence, Deception & Economic Warfare

For 2–4 Players • Ages 16+ • 120–180 Minutes

RULEBOOK v1.0

Overview

The Syndicate Market is a medium-weight competitive Eurogame set in a crumbling dystopian city where rival brokers fight to build networks of influence across 19 contested districts. Power is not taken by force — it is bought, bluffed, and calculated.

Unlike games that rely on dice for resource generation, every resource in The Syndicate Market is earned through high-stakes, hidden-bid auctions. Reading the table, calculating expected value, and weaponizing information asymmetry are the core skills. The wealthiest player is not automatically the strongest — their empire is a liability surface, and a coordinated underdog can dismantle it in a single turn.

Design Philosophy

Bluffing is not guessing. Every deception in this game has mathematical teeth. Players who understand expected value, Exposure Rating, and auction EV will consistently outperform those who rely on instinct alone.

Components

- 1 Hex Board (19 districts, pre-printed with district type icons)
- 48 District Cards (see District Card Deck section)
- 4 Syndicate Vault Cards (gold-bordered, separate deck)
- 30 Contract Cards (10 per Contract type, 3 types)
- 80 Cred tokens (denominations: 1, 3, 5)
- 40 Influence tokens
- 30 Data tokens
- 60 Heat tokens
- 16 Node markers (4 per player, in player colors)
- 24 Link markers (6 per player, in player colors)
- 4 Exposure Rating reference cards
- 4 Player screens (hides Cred and hand)
- 1 Round tracker
- 1 First Broker token

The Four Resources

Each resource has a distinct strategic role. No two are interchangeable, and each drives different bidding behavior in auctions.

Resource	Symbol	Primary Use	Risk Profile
Influence	Purple ♦	Network expansion, bribe NPCs, tiebreakers	Low — always useful
Data	Teal ◆	Intel denial, bid nullification, district abilities	Asymmetric — value shifts by position
Cred	Gold ●	Bid currency, Node/Link construction	Central — fuels everything
Heat	Red ▲	Liability. Offloaded onto opponents. Penalties scale with ER	Dangerous — a weapon and a curse

Cred — The Bid Currency

Cred is the lifeblood of your operation. It is the only resource used to bid in auctions, and also the primary cost for building Nodes and Links. Every Cred spent in an auction is Cred unavailable for construction, and vice versa. Managing this tension is the central economic challenge of the game.

Influence — The Expansion Fuel

Influence is spent to expand your network into new districts and to bribe NPC cards when they appear. It also serves as a universal tiebreaker: when two players tie in any contest, the player with more Influence wins. It is the most consistently valuable resource, which makes Influence-yielding auctions the most heavily contested.

Data — The Information Weapon

Data is used to activate Contract cards, peek at opponents' hidden information, and nullify bids. Its value is wildly asymmetric: nearly worthless to a player with a dominant network, potentially game-winning for a player clawing back from a deficit. This asymmetry makes Data auctions a rich bluffing opportunity — a desperate player may bid irrationally high or suspiciously low.

Heat — The Liability

Heat is not a resource you want. It accumulates from aggressive actions and must be resolved at the end of every turn. Critically, Heat penalties scale with your Exposure Rating — the larger your empire, the more each Heat token costs. Heat can be transferred to opponents through Contract cards, making it a potent offensive weapon as well as a liability to manage.

The Board — District Layout

The board is a hex grid of 19 districts divided into three concentric rings, each with a distinct strategic function.

The Core — 3 Districts (The Exchange)

The three central hex districts. These are always Syndicate Vault or Black Market Den cards — the highest-value, highest-Heat territory on the board. No player starts adjacent to the Core. Reaching it requires building 3 or more Links from any starting position, making Core control a mid-to-late game achievement.

Core Monopoly Rule

If any single player controls 2 of the 3 Core districts simultaneously, a Margin Call Contract is triggered against them at the start of the next round — even if no player holds a Margin Call card. This is a built-in board rule, not a card effect.

The Ring — 10 Districts (The Sprawl)

The contested middle band. A mix of Industrial Corridors and Ghost Infrastructure districts. This is the primary battleground for mid-game auctions and Heat-offload wars. Each Ring district is adjacent to at least 2 others, creating natural choke points — single districts that, if controlled, block rival expansion paths. Identifying and contesting choke points is the core spatial strategy.

The Fringe — 6 Districts (The Outskirts)

Starting territory. Two Fringe districts are pre-assigned to each player based on seating position. All Fringe districts are Residential Blocks — low value, low Heat, and safe. They provide a stable income base for early-game auction participation. As the game matures, Fringe districts become less valuable but still worth defending for their passive Cred generation.

Starting Setup

1. Each player places 1 Node on each of their 2 assigned Fringe districts.
2. Each player places 1 Link connecting their two starting Nodes.
3. Each player receives 8 Cred behind their screen.
4. Shuffle the main District Card deck and the Vault deck separately.
5. Place the First Broker token in front of the player seated to the dealer's left.
6. Set the Round tracker to Round 1.

Turn Structure — The Core Loop

On your turn, you execute four phases in order. Every phase feeds into the next. Other players may react during your turn via Contract cards at specified windows.

Phase 1 — Intel

Draw 2 District Cards from the top of the deck. Look at them secretly behind your screen. Keep 1 and place it face-down in front of you. Return the other face-down to the bottom of the deck.

The card you keep tells you what resource a district will produce this round and what contract it offers. Only you know what you're holding. This private knowledge is the seed of your bluff in Phase 2.

Contract Card Window A

Any player may play a Dead Drop Contract card during Phase 1, targeting the active player, before they choose which card to keep (see Contract Cards section).

Phase 2 — The Auction (Blind Escrow)

The active player nominates one district on the board to hold an auction. The prize is the resource yield printed on that district's currently-assigned card.

All players — including the active player — simultaneously and secretly place their Cred bid behind their screens. When all bids are locked, screens are lifted and bids are revealed at the same time.

Auction Resolution

7. The highest bid wins the district's prize.
8. ALL bids are paid to the bank — winners and losers alike. There is no refund.
9. In the event of a tied highest bid, the tied player with more Influence wins. If still tied, the tied player who bid earlier in turn order wins.
10. Losing players receive nothing unless a Contract card modifies this.

Expected Value of Bidding

$$EV(\text{bid}) = P(\text{win}) \times V(\text{prize}) - \text{Cost}(\text{bid})$$

Since all bids are paid, overbidding to bait opponents into costly losses is a legitimate EV play. Optimal bids cluster near $V \times (n-1)/n$ for n players.

Contract Card Window B

Margin Call may be played during Phase 2 before bids are revealed. Dead Drop may not be played during Phase 2.

Phase 3 — Build & Connect

After the auction resolves, the active player may spend resources to expand their network. All construction is optional.

- **Place a Node:** Costs 3 Cred + 1 Influence. The new Node must be placed in a district adjacent to an existing Node or Link in your network.
- **Extend a Link:** Costs 2 Cred. The new Link must connect to your existing network. A Link does not itself grant district benefits — only Nodes do.
- You may build both a Node and a Link in the same phase.

You cannot build in a district you are not adjacent to. Spatial pressure is the core constraint — you cannot simply jump to the most valuable district; you must earn adjacency.

Phase 4 — Heat Check

Resolve all Heat tokens you currently hold. Heat penalties scale with your Exposure Rating (ER).

Exposure Rating (ER)

$$ER = \text{floor}(\text{Cred_held} / 5) + (\text{Nodes} \times 2) + (\text{Links} \times 1)$$

ER is calculated fresh each Phase 4. It measures how visible and vulnerable your empire is.

Heat Penalty

$$\text{Penalty (Cred)} = \text{Heat_tokens} \times (1 + ER / 10)$$

A player holding 3 Heat with ER 20 pays 9 Cred. The same 3 Heat with ER 5 costs only 4-5 Cred.

Paying the Penalty

11. Calculate your Penalty using the formula above.
12. Pay that amount in Cred to the bank. Discard all Heat tokens.
13. If you cannot pay in full, proceed to Bankruptcy Resolution (see below).

Contract Card Window C

Liability Transfer may only be played during Phase 4 before penalty resolution. It transfers all your Heat to a target player with more Nodes than you, and grants you 1 Influence per token transferred.

After Phase 4, pass the First Broker token to the left. The next player begins their turn.

The District Card Deck

The deck contains 48 cards divided across five district types. Each type drives different auction behavior and risk calculations.

District Type	Count	Yield	Heat	Risk
Residential Blocks	16	2 Cred + 1 Influence	None	Low
Industrial Corridors	12	4 Cred OR 2 Data + 1 Influence (winner chooses)	None	Medium
Black Market Dens	8	6 Cred + 2 Influence	+2 Heat (mandatory)	High
Ghost Infrastructure	8	+1 Cred/round per adjacent Node for 3 rounds	None	Asymmetric
Syndicate Vaults	4	Unique per card (see Vault Card list)	Varies	Jackpot

District Type Details

Residential Blocks (16 cards)

Bread-and-butter economy. Always yield 2 Cred + 1 Influence with no variance. Their predictability is strategically significant: because everyone can calculate the prize EV precisely, bids cluster tightly. Overbidding becomes obvious. Use Residential auctions in early rounds to read opponents' bidding floors before committing to high-stakes contests.

Industrial Corridors (12 cards)

After winning this auction, the winner privately chooses their payout: 4 Cred OR 2 Data + 1 Influence. The choice is not revealed. This private selection makes the winner's true valuation invisible to opponents — they cannot calculate your bid ceiling because they don't know which payout you took. Industrial auctions are ideal for executing multi-card combo strategies.

Black Market Dens (8 cards)

The most contested cards in the deck. 6 Cred + 2 Influence is an excellent prize — but the mandatory +2 Heat means the true value depends entirely on your current ER. For a player with ER 5, the 2 Heat costs roughly 3 Cred at Phase 4, making the net prize approximately 3 Cred + 2 Influence. For a player with ER 20, those 2 Heat tokens cost 6 Cred — erasing nearly all benefit. A leading player who instinctively bids high on Black Markets is often paying for the privilege of harming themselves.

Ghost Infrastructure (8 cards)

Zero immediate yield. Instead, the winner receives a Passive Node Bonus: for the next 3 rounds, each of their Nodes adjacent to this district generates +1 Cred at the start of each round. Value ranges from 0 (no adjacent Nodes) to 9+ Cred over time (3 Nodes, 3 rounds). This massive private valuation asymmetry is precisely where bluffing thrives. A player with no adjacent Nodes may bid aggressively purely to deny the bonus to an opponent who does.

Syndicate Vaults (4 cards — gold border, separate deck)

One Vault card enters circulation per round, drawn from a separate shuffled pile. Each is unique and powerful:

- **The Armory:** Yields 5 Cred. Winner may nullify one opponent's bid this round after reveal, refunding them nothing (all-pay still applies to all other bids).
- **The Data Fortress:** Yields 4 Data. Winner may look at one opponent's hidden bid before all players commit their final amounts for the remainder of this auction round.
- **The Incinerator:** Yields 3 Influence. Remove ALL Heat tokens from the board — every player's, including the winner's. Resets the Heat economy.
- **The Shadow Ledger:** Yields 2 Cred + 2 Data. Winner draws 3 Contract cards and keeps 1, discarding the others face-down.

Contract Cards

Contract cards are powerful disruptors held in hand and played at specific windows during other players' turns. Each player begins with 2 Contract cards dealt randomly from the shuffled Contract deck. New cards are acquired through certain district effects and Vault cards.

Hand Limit

Players may hold a maximum of 3 Contract cards at any time. If you would draw a 4th, you must immediately discard one of your choice face-down.

The Three Contract Types

Margin Call

Play during Phase 2 (Auction), before bids are revealed. Choose one player. That player must immediately pay a Cred tithe equal to floor(their Cred / 4) into a public Bounty pool. The winner of this auction claims the Bounty in addition to the prize.

Strategic use: Forces the wealthiest player to contribute to a prize they may then lose. If they win, they broke even on the tithe. If they lose, they donated to their opponent. Also inflates prize value, baiting instinctive overbidding.

Dead Drop

Play during Phase 1 (Intel), before the active player chooses which card to keep. The targeted player must reveal both drawn District Cards. You then choose which card they keep; they discard the other.

Cost: 1 Data token. **Strategic use:** Destroys the target's information advantage. Forces them into a lower-value card and exposes their hand. Particularly devastating against a player whose bidding behavior you've been reading — they'll continue to bid as if holding the better card, out of habit or bluff, and overpay.

Liability Transfer

Play during Phase 4 (Heat Check), before penalty resolution. Transfer ALL of your current Heat tokens to one target player who has strictly more Nodes on the board than you. Gain 1 Influence per token transferred.

Restriction: Once per game per player (gold border indicator on the card). **Strategic use:** Converts your worst resource into your best. Dumps your accumulated Heat onto the highest-ER target at their brutal penalty rate. Even the threat of this card changes behavior — a smart leader will deliberately limit their Node count near yours to avoid being a legal target.

Bankruptcy & Node Seizure

When a player cannot pay their full Phase 4 Heat penalty, they enter Syndicate Default. Resolution occurs in three ordered steps.

Step 1 — Liquidation

The bankrupt player must immediately sell all held resources (Influence, Data, Heat removed from pool) back to the bank at half value, rounded down. Cred received from liquidation is applied immediately toward the debt.

Liquidation rarely covers a large penalty — selling 4 Data at half value yields only 2 Cred. But it prevents instant elimination, which is by design: a wounded player making desperate bids is unpredictable and strategically interesting. They alter the EV calculations of everyone at the table.

Step 2 — Node Seizure

If liquidation does not cover the remaining debt, the bankrupt player forfeits Nodes beginning with their highest-ER-contributing ones (Nodes before Links, most-connected first), until the theoretical debt is cleared or no Nodes remain.

Each seized Node is immediately placed up for open auction. This open auction interrupts normal turn order and is resolved before play continues.

The Seizure Auction

- All players bid openly (not hidden) in ascending order, starting at 1 Cred.
- The bankrupt player may participate if they have any Cred remaining from liquidation.
- The winning bidder pays the full amount to the bank.
- The bankrupt player receives half the winning bid as debt relief.
- The winning player places their own Node marker on the seized district.

Design Note — Why Open Auction?

Automatic seizure by the attacker who triggered the bankruptcy would make Liability Transfer and Heat-offloading too dominant. The open auction ensures the attacker must pay market rate — and other players can outbid them out of spite, self-interest, or strategic need. The attacker spent cards and resources to create the opportunity. Now they compete for it.

Step 3 — Elimination

A player who exits Step 2 with zero Nodes and zero Cred is eliminated from the game. In a standard 4-player game this is rare before Round 8. The liquidation and open auction systems

are designed to keep wounded players gasping along as long as possible, because their unpredictable desperation is part of the game's texture.

If a player is eliminated, redistribute their remaining Contract cards face-down equally among remaining players (excess cards are discarded). Remove their Nodes and Links from the board.

Winning the Game

The game ends after Round 12, or immediately when any player controls 4 or more Core and Ring districts simultaneously (a Syndicate Dominance victory). At end of game, calculate final scores:

Final Score

$$\text{Score} = (\text{Nodes} \times 3) + (\text{Links} \times 1) + (\text{Influence} / 2) + (\text{Cred} / 4)$$
Fractions are rounded down. Heat tokens still held at game end subtract 2 points each.

- Most points wins. In case of a tie, the tied player with more Nodes wins.
- A Syndicate Dominance trigger wins immediately regardless of score.
- Eliminated players are not eligible to win.

Quick Reference — Exposure Rating

ER Formula

$$\text{ER} = \text{floor}(\text{Cred} / 5) + (\text{Nodes} \times 2) + (\text{Links} \times 1)$$
Recalculated fresh every Phase 4.

Heat Penalty

$$\text{Penalty} = \text{Heat} \times (1 + \text{ER} / 10)$$
Example: 3 Heat at ER 20 = $3 \times 3.0 = 9$ Cred lost.

Auction EV

$$\text{EV}(\text{bid}) = \text{P}(\text{win}) \times \text{V}(\text{prize}) - \text{Cost}(\text{bid})$$
Optimal bid $\approx V \times (n-1)/n$ for n bidders.

Glossary

- **Blind Escrow Auction:** The core auction format. All players bid simultaneously and secretly. All bids are paid regardless of outcome.
- **Bounty Pool:** A temporary Cred pool created by Margin Call, awarded to the auction winner.
- **Cred Tithe:** The mandatory payment triggered by Margin Call, equal to $\text{floor}(\text{Cred} / 4)$.
- **Exposure Rating (ER):** A measure of your empire's visibility and vulnerability. Calculated each Phase 4. Higher ER = more expensive Heat.
- **First Broker Token:** Marks the active player. Passes left each turn.
- **Ghost Bonus:** The passive +1 Cred/round per adjacent Node awarded by Ghost Infrastructure districts.
- **Heat:** A liability resource accumulated by aggressive actions. Resolved in Phase 4 at a cost that scales with ER.
- **Link:** A network connection between two districts. Does not grant district income. Costs 2 Cred to place.
- **Node:** A network hub placed on a district. Grants district passive income and counts toward ER. Costs 3 Cred + 1 Influence.
- **Passive Node Bonus:** Income generated each round start by Nodes on active Ghost Infrastructure districts.
- **Syndicate Default:** The state entered when a player cannot pay their Heat penalty. Triggers Liquidation, then Node Seizure.
- **Syndicate Dominance:** An immediate win condition triggered by controlling 4+ Core and Ring districts simultaneously.
- **Vault Card:** A gold-bordered card from the separate Vault deck. One enters circulation per round. Uniquely powerful effects.